The Scopes Trial: Darrow Examines Bryan

Clarence Darrow & William Jennings Bryan · July 20, 1925

Source: The World's Most Famous Court Trial: State of Tennessee v. John Thomas Scopes (1925), trial transcript. Public domain. Darrow's examination of Bryan, continuous exchange.

> In the Scopes “Monkey Trial,” defense attorney Clarence Darrow put prosecutor and Bible expert William Jennings Bryan on the stand, exposing tensions between literal readings of Scripture and modern science in a landmark clash of the 1920s culture wars.

COMPLETE TEXT — UNEDITED

Examination of William Jennings Bryan by Clarence Darrow, of counsel for the defense (July 20, 1925):

Darrow. You have given considerable study to the Bible, haven't you, Mr. Bryan?

Bryan. Yes, sir, I have tried to. I have studied the Bible for about fifty years, or sometime more than that, but, of course, I have studied it more as I have become older than when I was but a boy.

Darrow. You claim that everything in the Bible should be literally interpreted?

Bryan. I believe everything in the Bible should be accepted as it is given there; some of the Bible is given illustratively. For instance: “Ye are the salt of the earth.” I would not insist that man was actually salt, or that he had flesh of salt, but it is used in the sense of salt as saving God's people.

Darrow. But when you read that Jonah swallowed the whale — or that the whale swallowed Jonah — excuse me please — how do you literally interpret that?

Bryan. When I read that a big fish swallowed Jonah — it does not say whale. That is my recollection of it. A big fish, and I believe it, and I believe in a God who can make a whale and can make a man and make both what He pleases.

Darrow. Now, you say the big fish swallowed Jonah, and he there remained how long — three days — and then he spewed him upon the land. You believe that the big fish was made to swallow Jonah?

Bryan. I am not prepared to say that; the Bible merely says it was done.

Darrow. You don't know whether it was the ordinary run of fish, or made for that purpose?

Bryan. You may guess; you evolutionists guess.

Darrow. But do you believe He made them — that He made such a fish and that it was big enough to swallow Jonah?

Bryan. Yes, sir. Let me add: One miracle is just as easy to believe as another.

Darrow. Just as hard?

Bryan. It is hard to believe for you, but easy for me. A miracle is a thing performed beyond what man can perform. When you get within the realm of miracles, it is just as easy to believe the miracle of Jonah as any other miracle in the Bible.

Darrow. The Bible says Joshua commanded the sun to stand still for the purpose of lengthening the day, doesn't it, and you believe it?

Bryan. I do.

Darrow. Do you believe at that time the entire sun went around the earth?

Bryan. No, I believe that the earth goes around the sun.

Darrow. Do you believe that the men who wrote it thought that the day could be lengthened or that the sun could be stopped?

Bryan. I don't know what they thought.

Darrow. Now, Mr. Bryan, have you ever pondered what would have happened to the earth if it had stood still?

Bryan. No.

Darrow. Don't you know it would have been converted into molten mass of matter?

Bryan. You testify to that when you get on the stand, I will give you a chance.

Darrow. You believe the story of the flood to be a literal interpretation? When was that flood?

Bryan. I would not attempt to fix the date. The date is fixed, as suggested this morning.

Darrow. About 4004 B.C.? That estimate is printed in the Bible?

Bryan. That is Bishop Usher's calculation. I would not say it is accurate.

Darrow. What do you think that the Bible itself says? Don't you know how it was arrived at?

Bryan. I never made a calculation.

Darrow. A calculation from what?

Bryan. I could not say.

Darrow. From the generations of man?

Bryan. I would not want to say that.

Darrow. What do you think?

Bryan. I do not think about things I don't think about.

Darrow. Do you think about things you do think about?

Bryan. Well, sometimes. (Laughter in the courtyard.)

Darrow. Have you any idea how old the earth is?

Bryan. No.

Darrow. Do you think the earth was made in six days?

Bryan. Not six days of twenty-four hours.

Darrow. Doesn't it say so?

Bryan. No, sir.

Darrow. Mr. Bryan, do you believe that the first woman was Eve?

Bryan. Yes.

Darrow. Do you believe she was literally made out of Adam's rib?

Bryan. I do.

Darrow. Did you ever discover where Cain got his wife?

Bryan. No, sir; I leave the agnostics to hunt for her.

Darrow. The Bible says he got one, doesn't it? Were there other people on the earth at that time?

Bryan. I cannot say.

Darrow. Does the statement, “The morning and the evening were the first day,” and “The morning and the evening were the second day,” mean anything to you?

Bryan. I do not think it necessarily means a twenty-four-hour day.

Darrow. What do you consider it to be?

Bryan. I have not attempted to explain it. . . . I do not see that there is any necessity for construing the words, “the evening and the morning,” as meaning necessarily a twenty-four-hour day, “in the day when the Lord made the heaven and the earth.”

Darrow. Do you think those were literal days?

Bryan. My impression is they were periods, but I would not attempt to argue as against anybody who wanted to believe in literal days.

Bryan. Your Honor, I think I can shorten this testimony. The only purpose Mr. Darrow has is to slur at the Bible, but I will answer his question. I want the world to know that this man, who does not believe in a God, is trying to use a court in Tennessee —

Darrow. I object to that. I am examining you on your fool ideas that no intelligent Christian on earth believes.

(The Court adjourned. The next day, Judge Raulston ruled that Bryan's testimony should be stricken from the record.)